

BEFORE

After the New Kingdom << 64–65, Egypt suffered a series of invasions, until Alexander claimed it for himself.



BRIEF RENAISSANCE

The Assyrians << 65, 80–81 were ousted, and native Egyptian pharaohs presided over a **renaissance** of their culture—the Saite era, c. 664–525 BCE.

LATE PERIOD

Achaemenid Persians << 92–93

dominated in the years 525–400 BCE.

Egyptians then ruled until 343 BCE, when the Persians returned to defeat **Nectanebo II**, the last native Egyptian pharaoh.

LATE-PERIOD
EGYPTIAN
GRAVE STATUE

ALEXANDER'S CONQUEST

In 332 BCE, **Alexander << 96–97** seized Egypt from **Darius III** (the last Achaemenid king) when he conquered the Persian empire.

p.75) there had been a Greek presence in Egypt (see pp.116–17), and the Ptolemies—educated, like Alexander, as Greeks—created a distinctly Greek court and system of administration.

Cultural coexistence

The Ptolemies did not impose their culture on the Egyptians. While the ruling class enjoyed a Greek lifestyle, in all other layers of society, Egyptian culture continued much as before. Furthermore, the Greek rulers styled themselves as native monarchs, taking the title of pharaoh. They even built Egyptian-style temples, and worshipped native gods. The parallel Greek–Egyptian culture is illustrated by the Rosetta Stone, with its Greek, hieroglyphic, and demotic scripts (see p.62).

Ptolemaic rule

If the Ptolemies' cooperative policy was a shrewd political strategy, it paid off, because their rule brought stability to Egypt. Reforms were made to land

location opened Egypt up to the trade and cultures of the Mediterranean. With its library of legendary fame, it became the world's center of Greek learning.

The Romans

By the middle of the 1st century BCE, the Ptolemaic dynasty was weakened by leadership rivalries. Rome had been increasing its role in Egyptian affairs and was now effectively overseeing the country. Independence was completely lost in 30 BCE, when Cleopatra VII (see pp.120–21) the last Ptolemaic ruler, allied herself with the losing side in the power struggles in the Roman Republic (see pp.110–13). Octavian, the victorious Roman leader, incorporated Egypt as his own personal domain.

Alexandria continued to flourish and became a meeting point for Roman trade routes. It also remained a center for Greek culture, visited by scholars from across the Greek-speaking world. In the early days of Roman rule, the Egyptian government kept its strong

Greek and Roman Egypt

Ancient Egypt's later history is one of fascinating change and diversity. Absorbed into the empire of the Macedonian Alexander the Great, Egypt joined the Hellenistic (Greek) world under the Ptolemies, before becoming a province first of Rome, and then of the Byzantine Empire.

When Alexander, the Greek-educated king of Macedonia, died in 323 BCE, Egypt was part of his vast empire, and its control passed to one of Alexander's trusted generals, Ptolemy Lagus, who had been his governor there. By 304 BCE, Ptolemy was king of Egypt, and his descendants would rule for 300 years. The "Ptolemaic" period of Greek rule in Egypt came at a time when Greek culture had a wide influence across the Middle East and Mediterranean—a movement known as Hellenism (see p.99). Ever since Mycenaean times (see

ownership, and agricultural methods improved. Regional administration was organized using the existing Egyptian "nome" system of administrative districts. With an energetic flair for

350 ft (107 m)—the reputed height of the Pharos lighthouse at Alexandria, second only to the pyramids

business, the Ptolemies also began to replace the Egyptian barter system with an early form of monetary banking, created royal monopolies on certain goods, and zealously explored trade opportunities. Ptolemy I moved Egypt's capital from Memphis to Alexandria—the new port-city founded by Alexander—where it was to remain for 900 years. Alexandria became the prosperous symbol of Ptolemaic rule. Its north-coast

Alexandria

This is a 6th-century Byzantine mosaic of the city, which was a leading center of Christianity by the 2nd century CE.

Greek culture, but the title of pharaoh became identified with the far-off emperor in Rome. Increasingly, however, Roman influences took hold. The Romans probably retained much of the Ptolemaic system of administration, but they slowly introduced many of their own practices in agriculture and everyday life. As Rome's power faded from the 4th century CE, Egypt came under the influence of the Christian Eastern Roman Empire based in Constantinople (once Byzantium, now Istanbul) and became a melting pot of different religious ideas.

Coptic Christianity

During the 1st century CE, Christianity spread to Egypt. By the later 4th century, it was the Roman Empire's official religion, and by the 6th, Egypt was strongly Christian. A devout Coptic church developed, which later became the principal Christian church in mainly Muslim Egypt. Copts held the "monophysite" belief that Christ was solely divine, and not both human and divine. In 451 CE the Eastern Roman Empire rejected the "monophysite" doctrine at the Council of Chalcedon (in modern Turkey), but the Egyptian Copts continued to adhere to it.

HOW WE KNOW

ALEXANDRIA HARBOR

In the 3rd century BCE, during Ptolemaic times, a great lighthouse was completed on Pharos Island, in the harbor of Egypt's cosmopolitan capital, Alexandria. This towering structure—destroyed by an earthquake during the medieval period—was one of the Seven Wonders of the ancient world. During the 1990s, archaeologists made some incredible finds underwater, including possible masonry from the lighthouse, and the remains of some impressive ancient statues. This image shows the recovery of a massive statue that may be one of the Ptolemaic kings.



Life on the Nile

The Nile River remained a vital artery for the Egyptians in Ptolemaic and Roman times. This mosaic from c. 100 BCE shows life along the river's banks.

AFTER



KHOSROW OF PERSIA ATTACKS THE BYZANTINES

Alexandria lost its status as the preeminent city of eastern Christianity to Constantinople (Byzantium 198–99 >>). The Arabs' arrival in 642 CE dramatically changed Egypt again.

STRUGGLES OF PERSIA AND BYZANTIUM

Persian king **Khosrow II** wrested control of Egypt from the **Byzantine emperor, Heraclius**, and ruled briefly (616–28 CE) before Byzantium won control back, between 629 and 641 CE.

ARRIVAL OF THE ARABS

Egypt then passed to the **Arabs 174–77 >>**. Caliph 'Amr ibn al-'As founded an encampment near Memphis that would later become Cairo, and introduced **Islam**, which dominates today.

